



Bioinformatics - A Beginner's Guide

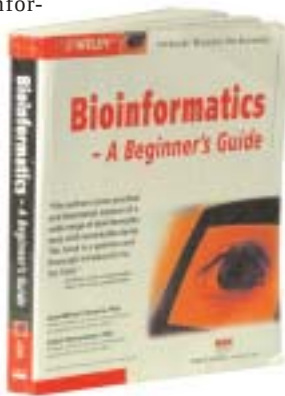
The DNA of simplicity

Man and the chimpanzee share about 96 per cent of their genetic material; the Human Genome Project generated 10 terabytes of data; Nascent Industry is already worth \$2.5 billion... These facts sum up Bioinformatics, an entirely new field that integrates molecular biology with mathematics and IT. It's a synergy of genomics, substitution matrices, progressive algorithms, Internet tools, computational methods, information storage and database analysis.

The Internet, with its endless amount of information, is an immensely powerful tool, but power is nothing without control—this book helps one

harness this awesome power and helps navigate through the plethora of information on bioinformatics.

This book is well researched and written by two of the world's leading Biogurus, Jean-Michel Claverie and Cedric Notredame.



It begins with an overview of the field and then guides you step-wise, through core applications such as the analysis of protein, DNA or RNA sequences, how to perform multiple tasks, finding a gene using various analysis tools, and how to explore different software programs and database collections. Though the book isn't exhaus-

tive, it's a boon for researchers and small and medium scale biometric firms without deep pockets—there are several free Web sites mentioned here. The authors steer us along using a bit of humour, and a lot of intensity and clarity.

Various software programs and database resources are demystified, and the authors provide tips and tricks to tweak these powerful tools to maximise performance. Popular programs such as Clustalw and BLAST, and databases such as Swiss-Port, have been used as examples.

An extremely useful feature are the listings—major databases, software programs and Resource Locations. This is a handy guide for the intrepid travellers into the world of RNA, DNA, genes, and millions and millions of Adenines, Cytosines, Guanines and Thymines.

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Linux Server Hacks

Hack that bird

The Linux operating system is capable of a lot, most of which is far from obvious. It is not uncommon for a less-experienced user to search the Web for hours before stumbling upon a rather obvious answer, which requires nothing more than the clever use of a few utilities. This is in contrast to the Windows world, in which everything is presented in the most easily available way possible. However, that is another religious debate.

Linux Server Hacks, by Rob Flickenger, is a classic O'Reilly publication—tiny, but packed with really useful content. The book describes itself as 'written for users who already understand the basics', which

is apt. If you're not completely comfortable with the command line, or if you think the MS-DOS Command Prompt is an expert utility for Windows administrators, you'll want to steer clear of this book.



Although there are some general tips here that would be of use to Linux power users, most are largely targeted at people who use Linux boxes as special-purpose servers. The eighth chapter is dedicated to 'Information Servers', which broadly covers tips for Apache, MySQL, FTP servers and BIND.

The Networking chapter shows you some clever things to do with IPChains,

IPTables and tunnelling. Of particular note for the subversive is a neat way around NAT, which is popularly used to grant controlled Internet access in office environments.

The book also has interesting exercises in the more mundane—taking backups, monitoring services, tracking file changes and so on. There's even a chapter on scripting which, unless you're fairly well-versed with Unix shell scripting, will seem like complete gibberish.

Overall, this is an indispensable book for the regular Unix administrator looking to speed up routing tasks or just looking to save time better spent goofing off. Home and novice desktop Linux users, please stay away for your own good. You have been warned.

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